

Build an Evidence-Based GTM Plan

Win/Loss replaces vibes with buyer truth.

The Takeaway: Don't build next year's plan and execute your GTM strategy on vibes. Run win loss to ensure your plan is grounded in buyer truth.

58%

of companies base at least half their regular business decisions on gut feel or experience rather than data.

SOURCE: BARC INFORMATION CULTURE SURVEY

Internal data only gives you one side of the story

CRM & CALLS	Show how you sold, not what the buyer actually decided.
COMPETITIVE INTEL	Comes from your reps, who weren't in the room when the buyer picked someone else.
INTERNAL TALKS	The buyer-side conversation that actually decided the deal never reaches you at all.



**Internal data on why you lose is closer to a
guess than a finding.**

~60%

of stated loss reasons don't hold up against what the buyer actually says.

This pattern shows up consistently across decades of post-decision
interviews.

*Nothing in your own systems closes that gap.
Talking to your buyers directly does.*



When to Run Win/Loss

Three priorities, whether you run it internally or externally.

1

Shape the plan

The highest-value moment is before the plan locks. Work backward from your deadline: external findings take about 60 days from kickoff. Internal looks faster. No kickoff, no procurement. But the reasons it hasn't worked internally before (bandwidth, competing priorities, nobody owns it) get *worse* during a planning sprint, not better.

2

Build around your knowns

Missed the planning window? Plan around what's already on the roadmap: a product launch, a rebrand, new messaging or packaging. You know these are coming: run win loss roughly 6 months before and 6 months after, to capture how the buyers' perspective changed.

3

Respond to the unknowns

A competitor ships something new, changes pricing, a new entrant shows up, or the market shifts under an acquisition. You can't schedule these, but they're exactly the moments when the plan's assumptions are most likely wrong. Run win loss when they happen, whether or not it was on the calendar.

WORTH NOTING

Many teams also work backward from their own year-kickoff presentation — often early in the year, though it varies by company — since having buyer evidence in hand for that moment is a strong way to open the year with tangible insights, instead of assumptions that often already have internal disagreement.

How to Do It: Internal vs. External

The answer is do win loss — the only real question is how. That comes down to one number: how many opportunities, won and lost combined, close in a typical quarter.

<200 CLOSED OPPS / QUARTER

Run It Internally

Real buyer interviews, in-house. Not CRM data. Mining closed-lost notes isn't win loss, it's the same vibes problem in a different format.

Participation: under 5% of losses, ~10% of wins agree to interview.

Incentive: budget ~\$100 per completed interview.

Time: ~100 hours a quarter from one team member.

Size it first: run your CRM numbers through the [free win/loss analysis tool](#).

Minimum for patterns: at least 15 loss + 5 win interviews. Below that, treat findings as directional. Repeat each cycle because one round is a snapshot, not a system.

200+ CLOSED OPPS / QUARTER

Bring In an External Program

At this volume, an independent program earns the line item in your plan. And running it on a cadence keeps the plan from being executed on vibes once it's live.

Cadence: two engagements a year, ~6–9 months apart.

Ran it in Q4? Run again in Q2 to cover Q4/Q1 deals.

Haven't run it in 6 months? Run it in Q1. An early signal if the plan's assumptions were off, before challenges compound.

Budget: \$30,000–\$50,000 per engagement (~20–30 interviews). Two a year, whether or not win loss already informed the plan. Split 6 months apart, one for a known trigger, one in reserve for the unknown.



Building the Case

Marketing, product & packaging, competitive intelligence, roadmap, and sales-execution decisions all run on vibes without real win/loss. The fix is the same regardless of function: talk to the buyer directly.

- 1 Commit to win loss.** Ideally it informs this year's plan. At minimum, it belongs in next year's plan as a line item, not an afterthought.
- 2 Decide the right fit.** Under roughly 200 combined closed opportunities a quarter, start internal. Above that line, scale to an external program.
- 3 Plan the resourcing.** Internal: budget the incentive, the interview time, and ~100 hours a quarter. External: budget for two engagements a year, worked backward from your planning deadline and known milestones.
- 4 Put it in the plan.** Not as a maybe. As a resourced, timed line item, the same as any other GTM initiative.

50%

Rigorous, ongoing win-loss programs see up to a 50% improvement in win rate and a 15–30% increase in revenue.

— GARTNER (TODD BERKOWITZ, RESEARCH VP)

Want help scoping the right-sized program?

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